

IELTS SPEAKING

Listen. Notice. Speak.

Four comic listening stories
for reflection, language and practice

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One listening can give you hours of practice

Don't try to learn everything at once.

1 LISTEN	First, follow the story. What is happening? What does each speaker mean?
2 NOTICE	Return to the transcript. Notice phrases, reactions, qualification, humour and repair.
3 BORROW	Choose language that could genuinely help you say something about your own life.
4 MAKE IT MINE	Answer a Part 1 question. Record yourself. Listen back. Change one thing and try again.

Natural speech is not a perfect written paragraph. Pauses, repetition, repair and small unfinished pieces are normal.

Cooking my family?!



LOOK FIRST

- What do you think the woman said?
- What might she really mean?
- Why is the picture funny?
- Would this mistake stop you understanding her?

SPEAKING CHECK

- Do small mistakes always destroy communication?
- If you notice a mistake, can you repair it and keep going?
- What can you say when you want to correct or clarify yourself?

I mean...

Use this when you want to correct, clarify or say an idea in a better way.

The examiner has to do all the work



BETTER GOAL

Give the listener something to respond to. Correct English can still be underdeveloped speaking.

SPEAKING CHECK

- Is the student understandable?
- Does he answer the questions?
- Who is doing most of the work?
- What could he add without waiting for another question?

A FEW LINES

Examiner: What do you like doing in your free time?
Student: I like football.
Examiner: Playing it?
Student: Yes.
Examiner: Watching it?
Student: Yeah, of COURSE!
Examiner: Why do you like football?
Student: It's good?

LISTENING 3

The toughest food critics in the house



BEFORE YOU LISTEN

- Why are the children holding 3 and 4? Why is the father holding 12?
- How does the mother seem to feel?
- Listen for language that makes her answer personal, funny and easy to follow.

Food critics - listen again and read

Examiner: Tell me, what do you like doing in your free time?

Student: Actually... it might sound a bit weird but... I... uhh... really enjoy cooking for my family. Yeah, honestly, I do, because... uhh... it's creative, y'know? I get to try out new recipes and, uh... well, my kids give me INSTANT feedback... you see, uhh... they're a bit picky. So... y'know, they're the best food critics I can get. [laughs]

Examiner: So... no hard feelings?

Student: No hard feelings... I mean, they're my kids, right? I still love them... even if they... uhh... turn their noses up at my shawarma. [laughs] Mmmmm... [sighs]

WHAT IS THE SPEAKER DOING?

- She gives a personal reason: cooking is creative.
- She adds a concrete example: her children give instant feedback.
- She jokes about the children being 'food critics'.
- She manages her message with actually, honestly, you see, I mean and right?
- She qualifies the final idea with even if.

Mine the language: useful spoken moves

actually
add, correct or slightly change what you are saying

it might sound a bit weird, but...
prepare the listener for something surprising or unusual

honestly...
show that you are giving your real view

you see...
introduce an explanation

I mean...
clarify, repair or develop what you just said

...right?
bring the listener into your reasoning

even if...
say that one fact does NOT change your main idea

y'know / you know
keep connection with the listener; sometimes gives you thinking space

NOTICE

These are not 'food vocabulary'. They are resources for managing almost any spoken answer.

Mine the language: personality and idiom

picky
difficult to please; only likes certain choices

food critic
someone who judges food; here she uses it jokingly about her children

turn your nose up at something
show that you think something is not good enough

they're my kids
a simple personal fact used here to explain her attitude

instant feedback
a reaction or opinion immediately

no hard feelings
I am not angry or upset about what happened

try out a new recipe
make or test a recipe you have not used before

I still love them
still = this remains true although there is a contrast

Make It Mine - food, family and free time

Borrow the language. Keep your own meaning.

1. What do you like doing in your free time?
2. Do you enjoy cooking? Why / why not?
3. Is anyone in your family picky about food?
4. Do you prefer eating at home or eating out?
5. Is there a food you like even if other people dislike it?

CHOOSE ONLY ONE OR TWO

actually • honestly • you see • I mean • even if • right?

picky • no hard feelings • turn your nose up at • try out

RECORD • LISTEN • RETRY

Does the borrowed language sound like you?
If not, change it. The goal is ownership.

LISTENING 4

The GOAT



BEFORE YOU LISTEN

- What does he seem to believe about himself?
- How do the other footballers react?
- Listen for two things at once: language he uses well, and evidence he judges badly.

The GOAT - transcript 1

Examiner: Number two. [long pause] What do you like doing in your free time?
Candidate: Well... I was born to be a star, actually.
Examiner: Right....
Candidate: I don't tell many people this, but... [laughs] well, actually, I'm ALWAYS posting about it online... [laughs]
Examiner: So you DO tell people...
Candidate: Well, yeah... but that's different. That's social media. [chuckles]
Candidate: You see... you know Messi and Ronaldo?...
Examiner: I've ... heard of them.
Candidate: No offence bu'... seriously? You musta been living under a rock...
Examiner: I musta been.
Candidate: Well, I'm, like, way BETTER than either of them. In fact, I'm probably better than both of them put together.
Examiner: Oh... BOTH of them?
Candidate: OH YEAH!
Examiner: Together?
Candidate: You're damn right!!

LISTEN BENEATH THE WORDS

Which lines are sincere? Which are sarcastic? Does the candidate notice the difference?

The GOAT - transcript 2

Candidate: It's just... there aren't really any scouts here in Dhofar, so... no one's discovered my talent yet.
Examiner: I see. And what level do you play at?
Candidate: Well... I play with my friends...
Examiner: Professionally?
Candidate: No...
Examiner: For a club?
Candidate: No...
Examiner: University team?
Candidate: No, no. Just with my friends.
Candidate: But they know I'm good.
Candidate: I mean, [chuckles] I post on social media a lot, y'know... you should follow me, you'd be really impressed... maybe you have connections in like Real Madrid or Chelsea...
Examiner: I'll have to check. Maybe I know... the King of Spain.
Candidate: Oh awesome... is he good at football?
Examiner: Not as good as you... but he's pretty famous!

EVIDENCE CHECK

He sounds certain. What actual evidence of elite football ability has appeared so far?

The GOAT - transcript 3

Candidate: Yeah... It's just... these days, ANYONE can be famous. I'm not saying your friend, that influencer guy isn't famous, bu'... not all fame is the same, feel me? I gotta say there's a lot of talentless rubbish on TikTok... and... [sighs] it's difficult for the real talent to get noticed.

Candidate: But me? I'm the GOAT.

Examiner: And what makes you think that?

Candidate: Well, I once scored an AMAZING goal!

Examiner: Really?

Candidate: Yeah. Well... I nearly scored it.

Examiner: You NEARLY scored a goal?

Candidate: Yeah. It hit the post. Coz it wasn't a real goal post, you know... not like on a professional field... otherwise it would've gone in.

Candidate: But my grandmother says I'm awesome.

Examiner: Does she know much about football?

Candidate: She's blind actually... so she's never seen a match. But she's VERY intuitive. She has Bedouin instincts, y'know.

CALIBRATION

Notice how every piece of contradictory evidence is reinterpreted so that his original belief survives.

The GOAT - transcript 4

Candidate: Anyway, my dad says I should get a degree in Chemical Engineering and... uhh... get a job at PDO.
Examiner: That sounds quite sensible.
Candidate: No, no, no! Think about it, right... What if Messi, right, had got a degree in Chemical Engineering...
Examiner: I imagine he'd probably be a chemical engineer.
Candidate: EXACTLY! He had THE VISION!
Examiner: ...That's not quite what I meant.
Candidate: See? That's the difference.
Examiner: What difference?
Candidate: I have... THE VISION.

THE PARADOX

He is expressive, responsive and often linguistically resourceful. His weakness is not simply 'bad English'. He repeatedly misreads tone, evidence and his own ability.

Borrow his language. Not his self-evaluation.

Mine the language: highly reusable spoken English

I don't tell many people this, but...
introduce something personal, surprising or slightly secret

well, actually...
correct, adjust or add something to what was just said

you see...
start an explanation

no offence, but...
warn that your next comment may sound critical

it's just...
introduce or soften an explanation

I mean...
clarify, repair or add detail

these days...
talk about the present period or a recent general trend

I'm not saying X, but...
qualify your view before making a contrast

not all X is the same
make a distinction inside one category

what makes you think that?
ask someone for the evidence behind a belief

Mine the language: idiom, condition and response

living under a rock
joking/critical: knowing almost nothing about something very well known

put together
combined: both people/things considered as one total

feel me?
very informal: do you understand what I mean?

otherwise...
if the situation were different / if that had not happened

What if...?
ask the listener to imagine a possible situation

Think about it, right...
ask the listener to follow your reasoning

Exactly!
strong agreement: yes, that is the idea

That's not quite what I meant.
a polite way to say someone misunderstood you

Not as good as you...
the literal words are praise; tone can make them sarcastic

I've... heard of them.
understatement can be humorous or sarcastic when something is extremely obvious

Meaning is more than vocabulary

Can you hear what the examiner really means?

“I've... heard of them.”	Of course she knows Messi and Ronaldo.
“Oh... BOTH of them?”	She is not genuinely impressed. She is highlighting how ridiculous the claim is.
“I'll have to check. Maybe I know... the King of Spain.”	She is joking and testing whether he notices.
“Not as good as you...”	The words look complimentary. The tone makes them sarcastic.
“That sounds quite sensible.”	Here she is sincere: his father's advice really does sound sensible.
“That's not quite what I meant.”	She politely signals that he has completely misunderstood her.

Make It Mine - interests, ability and ambition

Use his repertoire - but give honest evidence.

1. What do you like doing in your free time?
2. Is there something you think you're good at? Why?
3. Do you prefer playing sport or watching it?
4. Do you think social media is a good way to become famous? Why / why not?
5. What would you do if you suddenly had a chance to follow a big ambition?

LANGUAGE TO TRY

- I don't tell many people this, but... • well, actually... • you see... • it's just...
- I mean... • these days... • I'm not saying X, but... • not all X is the same
- otherwise... • What if...? • Exactly! • That's not quite what I meant.

CHALLENGE

Give a reason AND one piece of real evidence.

Four different speaking lessons

REPAIR	A mistake can be repaired. Keep communicating.
DEVELOP	Don't make the listener mine every detail from you.
QUALIFY	Reasons, examples, attitude and qualification create richer meaning.
CALIBRATE	Confidence helps. Evidence helps you judge yourself more accurately.
INTERPRET	Good listeners understand tone, implication, humour and attitude - not only words.

FINAL MAKE IT MINE

Choose any IELTS Part 1 question. Answer it once. Listen back.

Choose ONE change: repair • develop • qualify • interpret • use better evidence. Then answer again.